rahte hain. Atma-samman bhi koi cheez hai ya nahin?' (Elections keep happening in politics. Self-respect is more important), was his reply.

So, did Nitish make a mistake in making Modi's prime ministerial credentials a prestige issue? In pure electoral terms, he probably miscalculated. His own Kurmi caste was simply not large enough for him to be seen as a caste leader like a Lalu Prasad. He was hoping that the Muslims would 'reward' him for taking on Modi, but failed to realize that Muslims would rather back a leader like Lalu who they believed could actually defeat Modi. Nitish's original extremely backward and Mahadalit coalition was also eroded by the BJP's aggressive campaign.

In the end, Nitish perhaps just got a bit carried away by his own self-image as a defender of Lohiaite secularism and socialist values. Ironically, Nitish and Modi are not too dissimilar in several ways, a point I had emphasized in a column in June 2012 when the endgame was being played out. Both men have an authoritarian streak and keep an iron grip over their parties. Both are uncomfortable with dissent and have not allowed a second-line leadership to emerge in Gujarat or Bihar. Both also have a reputation for personal financial integrity.

They have similar family backgrounds. They had come up in life the hard way from mofussil towns—one from Vadnagar, the other from Bakhtiarpur. Both have kept their families firmly out of politics.

Modi had left his wife and family while still a teenager, while Nitish's late wife stayed away from him for extended periods. Both had cut their political teeth during the anti-Emergency agitation in the 1970s, but had taken very different ideological paths. One became an RSS pracharak and an eloquent defender of Hindu nationalism; the other is a passionate representative of socialist beliefs. Modi had publicly rejected Muslim headgear; Nitish was more than happy to wear an Islamic cap as a symbol of a plural heritage. Modi's economic model looks like a well-spun dream of market-driven growth and prosperity; the Nitish model is driven by a series of pro-poor schemes.

In 2014, like in any election, only one model and its leader could win. Modi, as an icon of change and hope, was that individual. Across Bihar, the